

billion during the holiday season of 2006 (Thanksgiving, Christmas, Hanukkah, and Kwanzaa). With the pressure to spend, spend, and spend greatly lessened, Melinda's family looked forward to the next holiday season for the first time that they could remember.

Only \$9.99 a Week

Although credit cards may seem like they are available to anyone who can sign the application, in reality there are people who will be turned down for credit when they apply. The reasons given may be lack of a credit history or having a negative credit history. Lack of a credit history is easier to overcome than a negative history since certain credit cards target young adults and make it easier to qualify.

Unfortunately, a negative credit history signals that you are not a good customer. In the late 1800s, some bankers did drive-by credit checks to determine if someone would be a good customer. Before they funded a loan, they would ride their horse past the applicant's home around dawn. If the light was on, they'd make the loan. They figured if someone was up that early, they were industrious and would pay them back.

Now in the twenty-first century, credit reports have taken the place of drive-by credit checks. If your credit report shows that you have paid late or not at all, the creditor assumes this pattern will continue. For those with negative credit reports, traditional channels of credit may not be available and many people are forced to look to other options for credit.

Jerome learned the meaning of a credit report the hard way. Neither his parents nor his school had explained to him the importance of paying his bills on time or at all. So, he frequently skipped paying some months and just caught up the next month with a double payment. Since he eventually paid, what did consistency matter? He was now twenty-one

